

Practice Paper 41 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Long, personal connection with the station

1 mark each for any two of:

- She has come in “every weeknight for seventeen years.”
- She still has “a key the new owners had not yet thought to ask back.”
- She knows the corridor’s familiar smells (“old carpet, warm dust... photocopier toner”).
- She recognises Marion’s handwriting at a glance.

Q2. [2] — Touching Marion’s note

1 mark — The action is **quiet and tender**; she does not eat the biscuit but treats the note itself as something precious.

1 mark — It suggests **affection for her colleagues** and an awareness that small, ordinary gestures are about to disappear with the station — a **silent farewell** to a shared working life.

Q3. [2] — Worn-down sliders (own words)

1 mark — The equipment is **old** and has been used heavily over a long period of time.

1 mark — The wearing in the exact spots “where our fingers went” suggests that a **small, consistent group of people** used the same controls in the same way for many years — a **close, settled team**.

Reject answers that lift “worn down to a softer plastic” without rewording.

Q4. [1] — Powering up in Geoff’s order

1 mark — It shows the narrator is keeping **faith with the routines and people of the station’s past**; even on the final night she honours the way she was **taught**, treating the closure with dignity rather than carelessness. (Also accept: it suggests deep respect for a mentor.)

Q5. [2] — Why she will not announce the closure

1 mark each for any two of:

- The general manager had **already issued a statement**.
- The local paper had **run an article** about it.
- “Anyone who needed to know, knew” — the news was already public.
- She wishes to do the show she “had always done” — preserving normality / dignity for her listeners on the final night.

Q6. [2] — Character of the station

1 mark — The details (birthdays, lost-cat notices, hospice-run appeal) show the station serving **small, neighbourly, everyday community needs** rather than chasing a large audience.

1 mark — They build the station’s character as **modest, kindly, and rooted in local life** — exactly the kind of unfashionable but valuable service whose loss matters.

Q7. [2] — Mr Ng’s voice changing

1 mark — The change in voice suggests he is **moved** / struggling to keep his composure; the call carries weight he cannot quite hide.

1 mark — It implies the weekly call was **much more than a song request** for him — a source of **companionship**, perhaps his main human contact, and he is grateful in a way that feels close to grief.

Q8. [2] — Hands flat on the desk

1 mark — The action suggests she is **steadying herself**, physically and emotionally, after a call that has affected her more than she expected.

1 mark — It conveys **restrained emotion**: she does not cry or speak, but the stillness shows that Mr Ng’s thanks have **touched her deeply**. (Also accept: she is grounding herself before going back on air.)

Q9. [2] — Literary device in “a particular kind of trembling...”

1 mark — Identification: **personification** of the trembling (it is described as having agency — it “begins” and “works outwards”), OR **imagery** / vivid physical description.

1 mark — Effect: it makes the emotion feel **physical and uncontrollable**, something that **spreads through the body** of its own accord; the reader senses how close she is to losing her composure even though she keeps it out of the microphone.

Q10. [2] — Letting the signal hum three seconds longer

1 mark — The small extension shows she is **reluctant to end the broadcast** — three seconds is her **private goodbye** to the station.

1 mark — It suggests the moment matters **more to her than she will admit**; the deviation from routine is a quiet, dignified acknowledgement of the ending. (Also accept: it shows tenderness, restrained grief.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly proud, dignified, reflective, content, steady, unsentimental.**
(Reject: **bitter, resentful, angry** — these miss the mood.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “A small but unmistakable rite of passage”

1 mark for understanding **rite of passage** — a **ceremonial / symbolic step** marking the transition from one life-stage to another (here, from childhood to adulthood).

1 mark for explaining that, although the licence itself is a **minor physical object**, it carried a **clear and recognised social meaning** — it publicly signalled that one had grown up.

Q13. [2] — Two statistical details

1 mark each for any two of:

- In the UK the proportion of 17–24-year-olds with a full licence has **fallen from around half in the early 1990s to under a third today**.
- Similar **declines** have been recorded in **Australia** and **much of Western Europe**.
- In **Singapore**, the **median age of new licence-holders** has **crept steadily upwards**.

Q14. [2] — Why owning a car is inconvenient for urban youth

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Parking is scarce and expensive**.
- **Congestion charges** (e.g. in London, Singapore) make a single weekday commute **more expensive than a monthly rail pass**.
- **Public transport** has become **more reliable and frequent** — making a car unnecessary.

Q15. [2] — “Unbundled the car from the licence” (own words)

1 mark — **Unbundled** means **separated / no longer joined together**.

1 mark — A young person can now **use a car** (by booking a ride on a smartphone app) **without needing to own one or hold a driving licence**; the two things, once inseparable, have been **prised apart**.

Reject answers that lift “unbundled” without rewording.

Q16. [2] — “Less like a passport and more like a piece of professional equipment”

1 mark — A **passport** suggests **freedom, adventure, and entry into adulthood** — the licence’s old, romantic meaning.

1 mark — A **piece of professional equipment** suggests something **practical and work-related** — the licence is now associated with **gig-economy driving as a job** rather than with personal freedom; its glamour has gone.

Q17. [2] — “A sensible jacket” / “saving anything at all”

(a) [1]: **Wry / dryly humorous / gently ironic** — the writer treats serious financial hardship with a light, knowing touch. (Reject: **sarcastic, bitter**.)

(b) [1]: The inverted commas mark the phrases as **imagined items on an ordinary young person’s spending list** — they signal that the writer is **quoting a typical young person’s own priorities** (or speaking in their voice), underlining how **modest** those priorities have become.

Q18. [2] — Contrast between generations (own words)

1 mark — To a **baby boomer**, a first car represented **freedom and independence** — the excitement of being able to go anywhere on one’s own.

1 mark — To many people **in their twenties today**, a car is an **embarrassing, outdated possession** — bulky, costly, and tied to an **older generation’s idea of success** that they do not share.

Reject answers that lift “keys jangling on a fob” or “slightly embarrassing object” without rewording.

Q19. [1] — Why the car sits “awkwardly”

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- Young people have grown up with constant news of **climate emergency** — melting ice, choking smog.
- Even an **electric car** still represents a **heavy, resource-intensive way of moving around**.
- Owning a car **clashes** with the **environmental values** younger people have absorbed.

Q20. [2] — Why the engineers’ assumption is “wobbling” (own words)

1 mark — For decades engineers built roads **expecting each generation to drive as much as, or more than, the one before**.

1 mark — That assumption is **no longer reliable**, because young people are **driving less**; the predicted demand for new road space is **not materialising**, so the planning logic is becoming unsteady.

Reject answers that lift “now wobbling” without rewording.

Q21. [2] — Groups for whom the car remains essential

1 mark each for any two of:

- People living in **rural areas**.
- People in **many parts of the United States**.
- **Families with small children**.
- People caring for **elderly relatives**.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Reasons young people are no longer learning to drive (Paragraphs 2–5):

1. Most live in **dense cities** where cars are **inconvenient** — parking is **scarce and costly**, and congestion charges raise commuting costs.
2. **Public transport** is now **more reliable and frequent**, so a car is rarely needed.
3. **Ride-hailing apps** let people use a car **without owning one or holding a licence**.

4. **Car ownership has become unaffordable:** prices, insurance and fuel have risen sharply while **wages have stagnated**.
5. Young people delay driving out of **environmental concern** / awareness of climate change.
6. The car has lost its **cultural prestige** — it now feels **embarrassing** and **old-fashioned** rather than a symbol of freedom.

Consequences for the way cities are planned (Paragraph 6):

7. **Road networks designed for peak car use** will become **over-built**, while **bus lanes, cycle paths, and pedestrian streets** will be **under-provided**.
8. Forward-looking cities (Paris, Oslo, Singapore) are **narrowing traffic lanes, expanding metro networks, and pricing private cars out of central districts**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Young people are turning away from driving because cities have made cars an awkward, costly inconvenience, while frequent public transport and ride-hailing apps offer easier alternatives. Vehicles, insurance and fuel have grown unaffordable on stagnant wages, and a car now feels environmentally and culturally outdated. As a result, planners are rethinking road systems: provision for buses, cyclists and pedestrians is insufficient, and forward-looking cities are shrinking traffic lanes, expanding metros, and pricing private cars out altogether.

Length count: 78 words from “Young” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —